ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Word, Excel and PowerPoint: Produce Assignments That Look Professional

The practical software skills behind clean reports, data work and presentations

DIGITAL SKILLS

Digital Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

A well-formatted report signals care; a spreadsheet that recalculates saves hours; a clear slide deck earns attention. This pack covers the specific features students actually need: styles, table of contents, page numbering, formulas, charts and presentation structure.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Format a long assignment using styles, headings and automatic page numbering.
- Insert a table of contents, figures and captions correctly.
- Use core Excel formulas, absolute references and simple charts.
- Design and deliver a short academic presentation.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Word: format once, not by hand

Manual formatting breaks the moment you edit. Use styles.

- Apply Heading 1, 2 and 3 styles to structure the document.
- Insert an automatic table of contents from the References tab.
- Add page numbers with a different first page where required.
- Use captions for figures and tables, then cross-reference them.
- Set consistent line spacing, margins and justified body text.
- Use track changes for group work and accept changes deliberately.

Excel: formulas that survive editing

The point of a spreadsheet is recalculation.

- Start every formula with equals and use cell references, not typed numbers.
- Relative references shift; dollar signs lock a row or column as absolute.
- Core functions: SUM, AVERAGE, COUNT, IF, VLOOKUP or XLOOKUP.
- Sort and filter before analysing; keep raw data on a separate sheet.
- Create charts from a clean table and label axes with units.
- Check totals independently rather than trusting the output.

> **The absolute reference habit**
> When copying a formula down a column, lock any cell it must keep referring to with dollar signs. This single habit prevents most spreadsheet errors.

PowerPoint: slides support you

Slides are visual aids, not a script.

- One idea per slide, stated in the title as a sentence.
- Use a readable font size and high contrast.
- Prefer a simple chart or diagram over a wall of text.
- Keep to a consistent template, colour and alignment.
- Rehearse timing and transitions; do not read the slides.
- Prepare for questions with two backup slides of evidence.

Word: structure first, appearance second

Most marks lost in typed assignments are lost to formatting chaos: inconsistent headings, manual numbering that breaks, paragraphs separated by blank lines, and a table of contents that does not match the page numbers. All of it disappears if you use styles properly.

Apply heading styles (Heading 1, Heading 2) rather than making text bold and large. Styles give you automatic navigation, a consistent look, and a working table of contents. Insert page numbers and a title page in separate sections so the numbering starts correctly.

Set the document up before writing: page size, margins, font, line spacing and the citation style your department requires. Then use Find and Replace for repeated corrections rather than editing by hand.

Excel: formulas, references and charts

A spreadsheet is a calculation engine. Every cell can hold a value or a formula beginning with equals. Relative references (A1) shift when copied; absolute references (A1) do not. Understanding that difference is the difference between a working model and a column of wrong answers.